

Zion Guardian Angels & Mountain of the Sun

When: September 20th to 23rd, 2012

Where: Zion, UT

Who: Matthew Hengst, Tina Bowman, James Barlow, Greg Gerlach, Gloria Miladin, Mat Kellier, Jen Blackie

Pictures: <http://www.flickr.com/photos/matthewhengst/sets/72157631612962297/>

GPS Track:

Angels: http://farm9.staticflickr.com/8315/8018694140_c34cd422f1_o.jpg

MoS: http://farm9.staticflickr.com/8461/8018694228_924b5004eb_o.jpg

The Angeles Chapter of Sierra Club has 4 (-ish) ratings for volunteer leaders that represent what sort of trips your allowed to lead.



O → On Trail (Or haha! This is a bike trail!)

I → Off Trail (Or trail? What trail? Why am I hiking through a bush and who is kicking rocks down on me?)

M → 3rd Class Rock & Snow (Or geeze I don't want to fall!)

E → 4th Class Rock & Snow (Or oh my god I'm going to be buried in a Sucrets tin if I fall!)



2nd class



3rd class



4th class

Since 4th class involves the potential for various unpleasant sorts of death the E rating is necessarily a bit harder to get. Generally people start at 'O' or 'I' and work their way up.

'O' just requires a basic one day first aid and CPR class, attending 5 Sierra Club O outings. Then you lead a single provisional where someone who already has the rating is along to see how you do and you're all set.

'I' requires you now do a 24 hour Wilderness First Aid class in addition to CPR and 5 official Sierra Club 'I' rated trips. Also you have to get a certain number of hours of wilderness interpretive hours in. And then there's the navigation checkoff where you're tested on basic topo map and compass navigation

skills. After all of that you can then plan two provisional's both of which have to have significant cross country travel so you can demonstrate your nav skills.

Now for 'M' you get in to the technical checkoffs. There's a written test you have to complete and separate rock and snow checkoffs the latter of which is held in the Sierra only twice a year and can be canceled due to lack of snow. Again two provisional's are required but instead of x number of M outings you submit a resume and are judged on overall experience. There are significantly less M leaders so provisional's get a little trickier to plan.

Then there's 'E'. It's the highest rating offered and effectively requires you to have gotten an M first. Then you redo the written test with more detail and more questions. There's a harder navigation checkoff with multiple components (map and compass, GPS, altimeter, written test, mock trip plan), a harder rock checkoff with more advanced techniques, and a more advanced snow checkoff, and after all of that you need **3** provisional's and the pool of existing E's who still climb and are willing / able to check you off is extremely small.

But hey, once you've ascended to the lofty heights of the E rating you get a cool patch with an ice axe on it. Totally worth it.

As I'm never content to let things sit I've been heading for my E since the moment I had my M (I started at O so I could get all the patches) and after completing the last of my checkoffs this spring I was ready for provisional's.

A low snow year plus my mystery illness killed my plans for getting all 3 provisional's done this summer but I managed to get Tina Bowman to agree to eval a late summer Zion trip.



There are two peaks on the Desert Peaks Section (DPS) list out there called North Guardian Angel and South Guardian Angel. Since I'm always wanting to make trouble I also included an unlisted peak that very few people climbed called Mountain of the Sun.

Due to the distances involved it was scheduled for 4 days in the end of September. Signup slots were limited due to the amount of time it takes to move people up and down while roped up and I had more than enough interest.

Everyone made their way to the Lava Point Campground in the Kolob Terrace area Wednesday September 19th ready to get kicked out of bed good and early on Thursday and get climbing.

Day 1: South Guardian Angel



A fire in Hesperia and a bad accident in Victorville had added another 2-3 hours to the usual 7-ish hour drive so Jen and I's mid afternoon departure didn't result in any extra sleep.

We ended up arriving late and with the campground full and James and Tina already asleep in our campsite we ended up bivying at the picnic area a few hundred feet down the road from the Lava Point Campground.

It turned out we had two people in the campsite, two people bivy'd along the road near the trailhead, and one person right next to us at the no camping picnic area. And yet we still managed to find everyone and get to the Wildcat Trailhead in order to get hiking by 7:30 am.

Both North and South Guardian Angel are accessed the same way from Wildcat with North being along the way to South.



That's north in the background on the right. It's only about two miles in and mostly on trail...



...mostly.

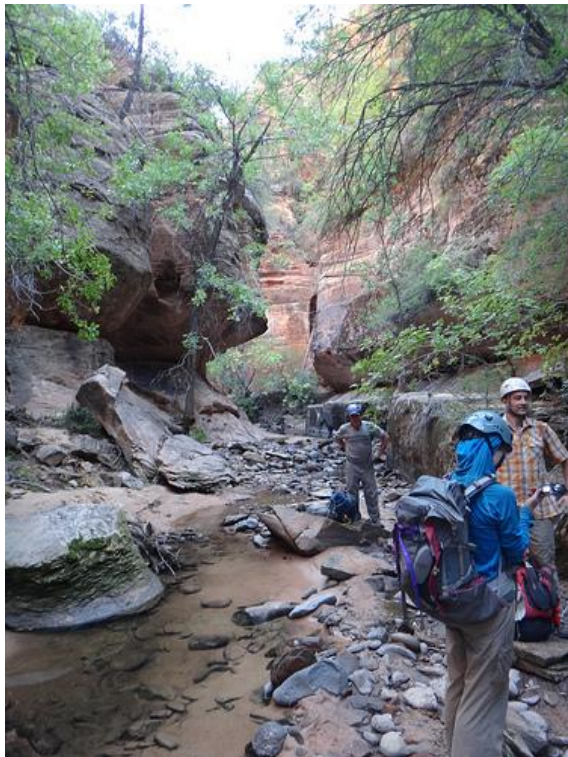
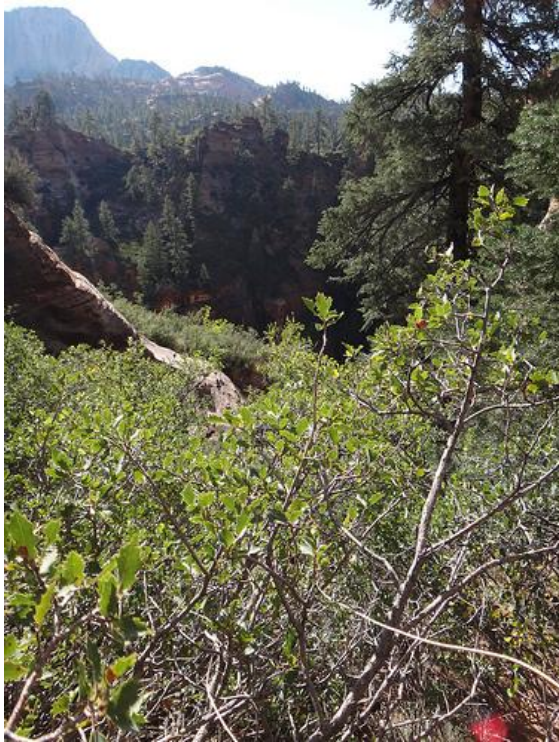
One you pass North Guardian you get a look as South in the distance.



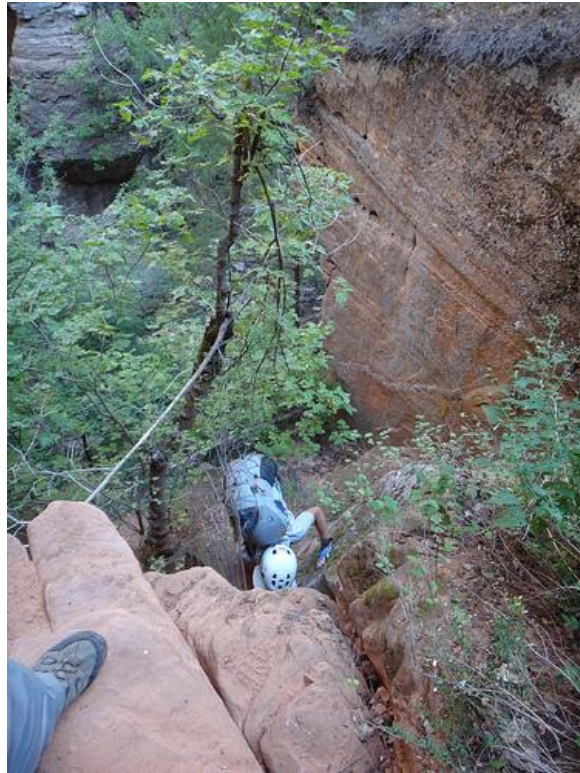
Not too bad but there's a little feature called the Subway you have to cross to get there. This involves making it down and up some rather brush filled cliffs and such.



We did a bit of exploratory bushwhacking but before too long found a steep somewhat brushy route down.



The Subway was nice and shaded with running water that we'd be grateful for on the way back out. After a quick rest it was time to climb out.



The route up is directly across from where you come down. There is a bit of a move on the way up but nothing that required a rope. We took our time and went up one at a time while the others sat around, took pictures, and hung on to trees.



Route finding up tends to go easier than down and we had a fairly clear route. Soon we were looking across as the route we'd climbed down.



Once on the far side of the Subway the route was easy.

As usual the view was depressingly pretty



I had a trip report from Steve Eckert that talked about starting to climb up the ridge right after two mushroom shaped rocks and related a 3rd class crux in the area. We found something promising right before the mushroom rocks and headed up there.





It was incredibly hot here and one person elected to stay below in the shade while the rest of us continued up.



SGA is the easier technical climb of the two Guardian Angels with only one real 4th class move serving as the crux.



We strolled up to the top enjoying the views.



This is actually the crux. It's right near the top and goes quite easily on the way up. Coming down you pay a little more attention as a slide would result in you taking the quick way down to the base of the peak several hundred feet below.



Of course we struck a pose of victory.



Since we had quite the walk back we didn't spend a while lot of time on the summit.



Down proved to be just as easy though we took time walking people through the 4th class bit.



From there it was an easy walk down.





The return was uneventful except for the climb down into The Subway where we pulled out the rope to bypass that one somewhat tricky move.



Once down most all of us topped off our water. I didn't bother filtering but some people used tablets.

From here it was just a climb back out the far side.



Since we knew the route it went fast.



Looking back at SGA.



Walking past NGA.

Having made the longer trek today the second day was set to be much easier. We'd have a bit more rope work but it wasn't nearly as far in. This was by design as we'd be relocating into the park proper at the end of the day.

We drove back to Lava Point Campground and had a nice campfire and happy hour before turning in late.

Day 2: North Guardian Angel

We packed up all our gear and were back at the Wildcat Trailhead again early enough to get some use out of our headlamps.



This did not upset me.

We retraced our steps from the day before and instead of passing to the left of NGA headed straight for it.

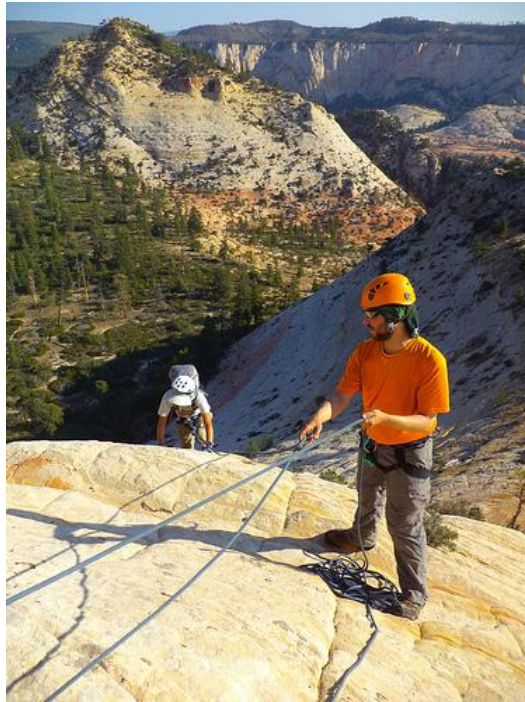


You actually climb directly up to the bench on the left. On approach this looks horrifying but in person it isn't bad.



I think I need to start giving acting lessons to participants.

Once up on the bench you make a hard right and climb the ridge proper. The first part is a decently exposed bit so out came the rope and I climbed up, set an anchor, and brought the rest up behind me.



The climbing was easy enough I kept my boots on and whenever something looked borderline I just went a bit further to the right.



Once everyone was up the rope was put away and we continued up.



There was one spot we really had to pay attention where you cross over a small rib. Going up there's a good handhold that let us talk everyone through though we'd rope up for a rappel coming down.



Not that bad a move, just exposed.



Soon we made the summit ridge.



And struck a pose of victory.

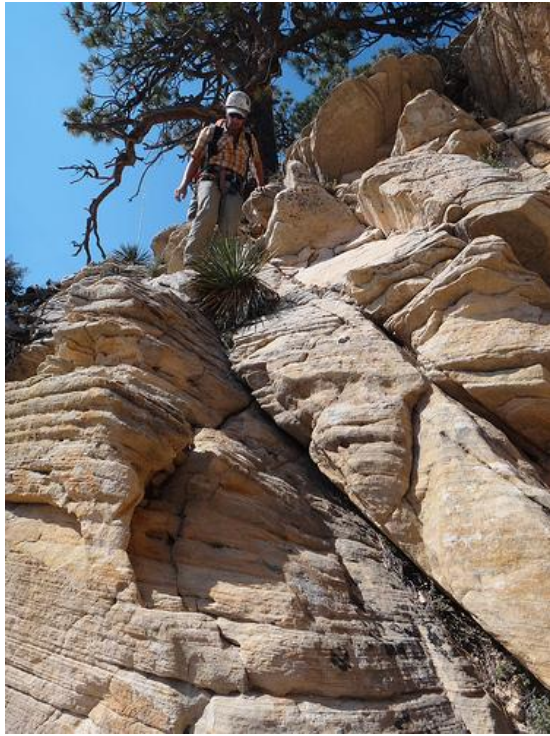




We had a nice view of SGA across the way.



And Tina and I shared a leadership moment. (Beards. Pure mountain power)



After a good break up top we packed up and headed down.





To avoid the awkward rib we used a nearby tree and rappelled down to a ledge below.



Camera angle is everything...

We also rapped the last bit above the saddle that we'd roped up for climbing up.



We hightailed it back up the trail to the cars and set off the Zion proper.



Watchmen Campground is immediately inside the park itself and was close enough to town we could make the ever important beer run (having made a rather sizable dent in the supply we brought after two hot days).



We managed to entertain ourselves until dark when we could have a fire.





It was a pleasant evening though warm and a bit windy after dark. We all got a good night's sleep in preparation for the expected rough hike to Mountain of the Sun the next day.

Day 3: Mountain of the Sun

This day was actually the biggest question mark as we were aiming for a peak that wasn't on the list and only had limited information out there about it.

I'd originally looked down on the peak with Anne last year when we climbed Deertrap Mountain during the Thanksgiving Extravaganza.



From there it looked rather hideously steep but I later did some more poking around and found some information that indicated it was just a scramble. I also contacted the author of an out of print Zion peakbagging guide who also recommended it as a worthwhile jaunt.



I wanted us hiking before dawn just in case the bushwhacking and route finding took longer than expected. Everyone leapt out of bed with bountiful amounts of enthusiasm

Oh yes, feel the enthusiasm.

We piled in to two vehicles and drove through the Zion tunnel to the pullouts at Pine Creek Canyon.



The route information I had said to head north and climb out of Pine Creek immediately to the left of a waterfall. Instead we ended up climbing a fairly obvious route to the right of some slick slabs that might possibly be called a waterfall....maybe...



Once up top we had occasional ducks and even a footprint or two along the way.



We were carrying quite a bit of water after the previous two hot days and ended up leaving a bit as we swung around the southern ridge of Deertrap.

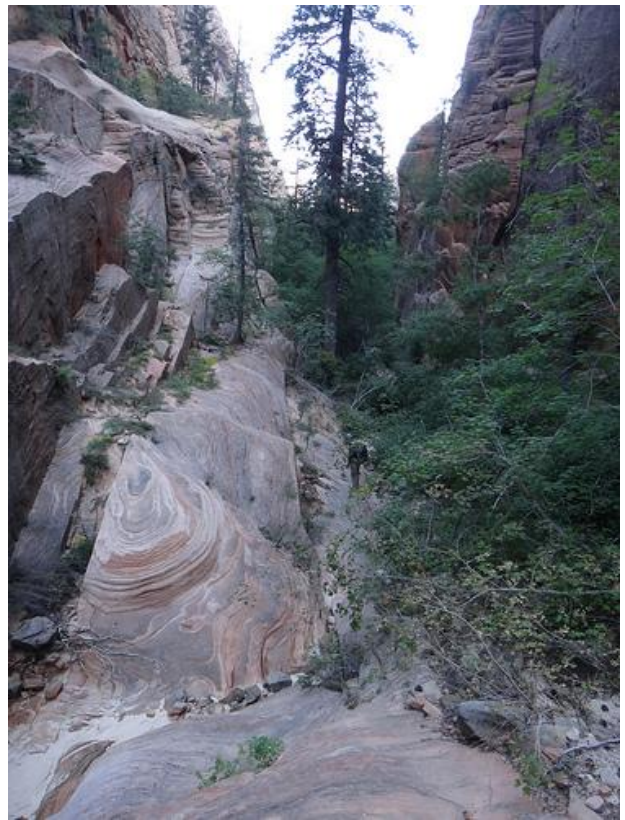
Once we turned the corner we crossed a small ridge and dropped between Deertrap and Twin Brothers. This is apparently how you get to the head of Spry Canyon.



We hiked over to Twin Brother and turned North again.



This climbed to a sharp saddle and then dropped sharply.



The terrain varied from loose dirt to slick but solid rock and the occasional mini grove.



We were actually lucky it was late in a relatively dry year as we came across several spots that would have been far trickier to negotiate had there been more water. As it was the worse we had to contend with was wet sand and an occasional puddle.



This gully led us past the eastern flank of Mountain of the Sun before opening up next to a rather nice looking ramp leading back south. But before we'd do that I had a waypoint I'd found that was labeled cave.

But before we'd start up the ramps to the peak itself

CAVE!!! Hole in the ground! Likely damp and foul smelling!

We dropped our packs and shot went poking around the corner.

At first it just looked like a slot canyon.



But if you continue back it's actually suitable impressive if a bit short.



Jen is wedged in the furthest point just far enough in you need a headlamp (or a camera with a flash like we had)



We took our pictures and I commented that the best possibly way to lead this peak would be climbing down from the summit to the top of the cave then rappaging down to the floor. Next time!

And with that little diversion behind us it was time to climb the actually peak.

Some surprisingly pleasant and solid ramps lead from the floor of the canyon south. They are steep but good solid rock.



Near the saddle you traverse some fairly low angle slabs to reach the saddle proper. Here we left some more water then climbed up another northern ramp.



The distinct orange rock band leading up from the left looked like it might work but you actually end up on the wrong side of a small but nasty looking gap. Much better to head up the slope directly.



The obvious slope has a fairly long and steep slab near the beginning then dumps you into a loose chute on the left with slab and trees on the right.



We never roped up though this section was a bit borderline and we'd rap down it on descent.

At one point 2/3 of the way up there was a horizontal ledge leading off to that left that looks very tempting. This leads to a very very exposed ledge about as wide as a boot crossing a slab. This then leads to a solid but rather 4th class ridge that takes you almost right up to the summit.



Jen and I scouted it but I didn't want to rope the group up across the ledge so we took the main group further up the original ramp. This was loose and had one particular exposed bit but kept things generally class 2.



The views were rather nice along the way.



That put us on the summit ridge which as seems to the norm in Zion is open and flat.

And this was our view...



...not bad.



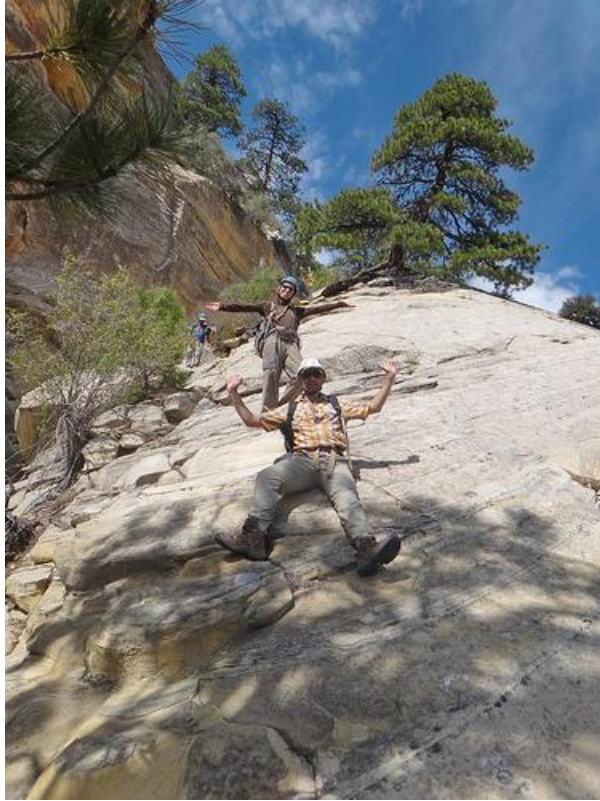
5-1-12	Space	Shirley	Happy New Year!
5-2-12	Space	Shirley	Happy New Year!
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5-14-12	Space	Shirley	Happy New Year!
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5-16-12	Space	Shirley	Happy New Year!
5-17-12	Space	Shirley	Happy New Year!
5-18-12	Space	Shirley	Happy New Year!
5-19-12	Space	Shirley	Happy New Year!
5-20-12	Space	Shirley	Happy New Year!
5-21-12	Space	Shirley	Happy New Year!
5-22-12	Space	Shirley	Happy New Year!
5-23-12	Space	Shirley	Happy New Year!
5-24-12	Space	Shirley	Happy New Year!
5-25-12	Space	Shirley	Happy New Year!
5-26-12	Space	Shirley	Happy New Year!
5-27-12	Space	Shirley	Happy New Year!
5-28-12	Space	Shirley	Happy New Year!
5-29-12	Space	Shirley	Happy New Year!
5-30-12	Space	Shirley	Happy New Year!
5-31-12	Space	Shirley	Happy New Year!



And Tina and I shared another leadership moment.



While we didn't use the rope coming up two brief sections were exposed enough we pulled it out coming down.



That isn't one of them.

The first was near the top in a small chute that wasn't very long or steep but had a large drop at the bottom.



The second was when we were almost down to the saddle where there is an extended slab. Again you could downclimb but one stumble would have rather dire consequences. There was even a rap station set up here we used.



From here it was just retracing our steps.





We did make a small detour to see some faint petroglyphs I'd heard about.



There were just a few and were somewhat faint but worth the 5 minute detour.



Once again we made it out with no headlamps required much to my despair and sadness.



Tina was happy to be out early as she had been hoping to leave that night. She soon departed and the rest of us made another beer run and relaxed around the campfire.



Day 4: Quick Angels Landing and Home

We'd done everything planned for the official trip but it seemed like a waste to spend an entire day just driving home.



Nevertheless several people were more interested in getting home to families instead of spending part of the day with our increasingly fragrant persons so the trip was officially ended leaving only Jen, James, and myself looking to entertain ourselves.

We decided to do the iconic Angel's Landing since Jen had never been to Zion before and James had been there in the winter when snow and ice made the last section too precarious.



So we jumped on the Zion shuttle and headed for the Grotto stop.



We even caught sight of Mountain of the Sun out the window.



I'm really entertained by the Zion "hey dummy you can fall" icons though I pointed out the stick figure looked to be in more danger of a very painful broken tailbone than actual death.

The signs are quite insistent on the whole you might die thing...



Nevertheless it's actually a trail most of the way. We threw on our packs and hiked up passing people left and right.





This is about where people who don't like heights start turning back. There's usually a rather large collection of people waiting for friends and family to come back from the summit.



We tried to show proper fear and excitement.



There's still a trail here with bucket steps cut in the rock and chains to hold on to but you could conceivably fall off if you were goofing around. (I'm guessing the fatalities were 20something males and boyscouts personally...)



The landing of Angel's Landing. Even with the crowds we were up top about an hour after leaving the bus.



The views are of course spectacular but this is Zion. It's expected. And we struck a pose



This somehow attracted a few odd looks from other people on the summit. Guess people aren't used to seeing UCI sweatshirts or something...

The biggest challenge down was working our way through the throngs of people clinging to the chains for dear life.



Once down we said goodbye to James who was headed for the Narrows to play around before going home. (As a 29 Palms resident he had about 2 hours less of driving.)

From there it was straight home with a brief stop in Springdale to get Mexican food and a short diversion near the Nevada border to check out a rather epic looking solar plant under construction.



http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Ivanpah_Solar_Power_Facility if you're curious.

We made it home sometime around 7 pm which was a nice if somewhat disturbing development letting me get everything cleaned up before the trip to Boise the following week. 4 days of work then off to the Sierra to attempt Picket Guard and Kern Point in the last big butt kicker backpack of the summer.

So once all the paperwork is in this trip will count as the first of my three E provisionals. The second (another rock trip) should be in early December and the third is planned for spring when we have snow to climb.